LIFELONG OPPORTUNITY

DATA ANALYST

A Free Guide to Career Fit, Affordable Education, Accessibility, Ethical Employment, and Lifelong Reinvention

For people of all ages, abilities, backgrounds, and income levels

Alberto (Al) Leiva

Created and directed by Alberto (Al) Leiva

Research, organization, editing, and document preparation assisted by ChatGPT, OpenAI

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This guide does not guarantee employment, funding, certification, promotion, remote work, or a particular salary. It helps readers understand the work, verify requirements, compare pathways, and protect themselves before committing.

Why I Created This Guide

I created the Lifelong Opportunity Guides to help people pursue education and meaningful work without being excluded by age, disability, income, location, or a nontraditional life history. I live with dysgraphia and am on the autism spectrum. I began this project at age 70.

Collect, clean, analyze, visualize, and explain data to support decisions while protecting quality, privacy, and fairness.

Acknowledgment of AI Assistance

I conceived, directed, and take responsibility for this guide. ChatGPT by OpenAI assisted with research organization, editing, and document preparation. AI assistance does not replace official sources, qualified professionals, human judgment, or verification.

Ethical and Practical Limits

- No school, credential, recruiter, or employer can guarantee an outcome.
- Requirements vary by employer and jurisdiction and change over time.
- This guide is educational, not individualized legal, tax, medical, immigration, financial, or vocational advice.
- Never pay a large nonrefundable fee because of pressure or an unsupported promise.

Table of Contents

1. How to Use This Guide

A careful decision process

- Begin with the real work, not a school advertisement.
- Verify local requirements before paying.
- Review at least 25 current job postings.
- Test your interest with fictional, public, or supervised activities.
- Keep every promise, cost, accommodation, and repayment term in writing.

2. What the Work Involves

Purpose and settings

Collect, clean, analyze, visualize, and explain data to support decisions while protecting quality, privacy, and fairness.

Common work settings
business and nonprofit organizations
healthcare, government, education, and research
finance, marketing, and operations
consulting and technology firms

Work cycles and decisions

- Define the question and required evidence.
- Collect and profile authorized data.
- Clean, transform, and validate datasets.
- Perform descriptive and appropriate statistical analysis.
- Create accessible charts and explanations.
- Document assumptions, reproducibility, limitations, and decisions.

A normal work cycle includes preparation, execution, documentation, quality review, communication, and follow-up. High-consequence decisions require evidence, authority, and timely escalation.

3. Duties, Tools, and Definitions

Common duties

- Define the question and required evidence.
- Collect and profile authorized data.
- Clean, transform, and validate datasets.
- Perform descriptive and appropriate statistical analysis.
- Create accessible charts and explanations.
- Document assumptions, reproducibility, limitations, and decisions.

Tools and records

- Spreadsheets.
- Sql.
- Python or r where required.
- Visualization and bi tools.
- Version control, notebooks, and data catalogs.

Plain-language terms

Term	Meaning
Scope	The work a person is trained, authorized, and permitted to perform.
Escalation	Sending a concern to the person with authority or expertise to act.
Data lineage	A record of where data came from and how it changed.
Access control	Rules that limit who may view or change systems and information.
Change control	A documented process for assessing, approving, testing, and recording changes.

4. Fit and Accessibility

Career-fit questions

- Do I enjoy the actual recurring tasks?
- Can I meet or safely adapt the concentration, communication, physical, and schedule demands?
- Can I tolerate incident pressure, ambiguity, and continuous learning?
- Is the training cost realistic under conservative wage assumptions?
- Do local employers accept the pathway I am considering?

Accommodation planning

- Verify accessibility in courses, labs, internships, employer training, testing, and remote systems.
- Ask separately about accommodations from the school, employer, placement site, and credential body.
- Consider captioning, screen readers, ergonomic equipment, alternative input, flexible scheduling, written instructions, and reduced-distraction space.

- Do not assume remote work eliminates disability barriers.

5. Ethics, Safety, and Boundaries

Scope and escalation

- Do not invent, suppress, or selectively exclude data.
- Do not reidentify people or use data beyond consent and authorization.
- Test for bias, leakage, and misleading visual scales.
- Do not claim causal conclusions from inadequate evidence.

Health and workload

- Manage prolonged screen time, posture, repetitive input, fatigue, and on-call expectations.
- Use breaks, ergonomic adjustments, workload escalation, and psychological-safety resources.
- Do not normalize harassment, retaliation, impossible deadlines, or unsafe staffing.
- Document material risks and decisions honestly.

6. Pay, Benefits, and Outlook

National starting point

BLS does not provide one universal data-analyst wage; related May 2024 medians include $112,590 for data scientists and $91,290 for operations research analysts.

Related data occupations are projected to grow rapidly, but entry-level competition and title variation are significant.

Local research

- Compare entry, median, and higher ranges rather than one advertised salary.
- Separate base pay from bonuses, overtime, equity, contract rates, and on-call compensation.
- Research benefits, tuition support, equipment, internet, travel, certification, and unpaid administrative costs.
- Verify whether a role is remote, hybrid, onsite, location-restricted, employee, contractor, or temporary.
- Treat national statistics as context, not a promise.

7. Education and Credentials

Free-first pathway

- Begin with public libraries, official tutorials, open courses, community colleges, employer training, and supervised practice.
- Build foundations before paying for advanced credentials.
- Use portfolio evidence that does not expose confidential or copyrighted material.
- Pay only when a program creates a verified next step.

School and credential verification

- Verify accreditation, credit transfer, completion data, total cost, refund policy, and complaint process.
- Confirm whether employers actually request the credential.
- Check expiration, renewal, continuing education, exam retakes, and geographic portability.
- Distinguish vendor training from a broadly portable education.
- Avoid bootcamps or programs that guarantee jobs or hide outcomes.

8. Employer-Supported Learning

Tuition and repayment

- Employers may cover tuition, certifications, conferences, books, software, equipment, and paid training time.

- Obtain prior approval and the full agreement in writing.
- A service commitment may last up to two years and may require full or prorated repayment after voluntary departure.
- The agreement should explicitly address layoffs, position elimination, restructuring, disability, military service, retirement, and employer-directed transfer.
- Verify tax treatment and do not double-count the same expense for multiple benefits.

Internships and career ladders

- Distinguish internships, apprenticeships, cooperative education, residencies, mentoring, and ordinary probationary employment.
- Verify pay, supervision, productive-work expectations, credential ownership, and conversion claims.
- Ask whether cross-training leads to recognized skills, promotion eligibility, or merely additional duties.
- Keep evidence of completed competencies and work hours.

9. Privacy, Cybersecurity, and Ethical AI

Responsible data and technology

- Use only authorized data, systems, accounts, and tools.
- Do not enter confidential, personal, proprietary, source-code, or security-sensitive information into public AI systems.
- Verify AI output and disclose material AI assistance where required.
- Do not fabricate analysis, test results, tickets, credentials, references, code, or project status.
- Protect secrets, multifactor authentication, portable devices, backups, logs, and audit evidence.
- Report suspected compromise, unauthorized access, data loss, or manipulation promptly.

10. Portfolio, Résumé, and Interview

Evidence of ability

- Create two occupation-specific projects using fictional, public, or fully sanitized information.
- Show the question, method, evidence, quality checks, limitations, and escalation points.
- Include accessible documentation and a short explanation for nontechnical readers.
- Never publish employer-owned data, code, diagrams, credentials, or screenshots without permission.

Application preparation

Interview question	Strong answer should show
Describe a difficult problem you investigated.	Method, evidence, communication, and verification.
How do you protect sensitive information?	Minimum access, approved tools, and escalation.
What do you do when evidence conflicts?	Reconciliation, documentation, and uncertainty.
How do you handle work outside your authority?	Boundaries and timely escalation.
How do you learn a new system?	Structured practice, documentation, and feedback.

11. Advancement and Exit Planning

Career ladder

- Data-entry, reporting, or operations role.
- Junior data analyst.
- Data analyst or analytics specialist.
- Senior analyst, bi, data science, governance, or analytics management.

Portability and change

- Keep transcripts, credentials, project evidence, evaluations, and continuing-education records.
- Identify adjacent roles with different coding, mathematical, physical, schedule, or customer demands.
- Understand employer repayment before leaving.

- Preserve documentation showing your contribution without retaining confidential property.
- Reassess the path when automation, health, family, or labor-market evidence changes.

12. Before You Enroll or Sign

Verification checklist

- I understand the real daily work.
- I verified employer and education requirements.
- I calculated total cost and lost income.
- I verified accessibility across the pathway.
- I understand employer funding, repayment, and layoff terms.
- I checked credential portability and renewal.
- I understand privacy, intellectual-property, and portfolio restrictions.
- I have an exit and adjacent-career plan.

13. Twelve-Week Action Plan

Sequential plan

1. Weeks 1–2: Define strengths, constraints, accessibility needs, and nonnegotiable conditions.
2. Weeks 3–4: Study the occupation's work cycles, tools, risks, and boundaries.
3. Weeks 5–6: Analyze local job postings, wages, schedules, and employer requirements.
4. Weeks 7–8: Compare education, credentials, employer pathways, and total cost.
5. Weeks 9–10: Complete two ethical practice projects and request feedback.
6. Weeks 11–12: Prepare application evidence and decide whether to proceed, pause, or change direction.

14. Worksheets

Career fit and cost

Prompt	Your notes
Tasks I enjoy	
Tasks or conditions I must avoid or accommodate	
Local requirements	
Total education and equipment cost	
Conservative entry pay	
Major unresolved risk	

Employer agreement

Question	Written answer
What expenses are covered?	
What grade, exam, or performance rule applies?	
How long must I remain employed?	
How is repayment prorated?	
What happens after layoff or position elimination?	
Who owns credentials and work products?	

15. Sources and Maintenance

Official starting sources

- https://www.bls.gov/ooh/math/data-scientists.htm
- https://www.bls.gov/ooh/math/operations-research-analysts.htm
- Current state, national, or professional licensing and education authorities where applicable.
- Current local job postings and employer policies.

- IRS guidance for education credits and employer educational assistance.

Release policy

- Status: Release candidate pending owner review.
- Factual review date: July 2026.
- Next scheduled review: July 2027 or sooner after a material change.
- Corrections should identify the guide, section, evidence, and proposed change.